

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7) — Paper 4

Chapter 8: How the Land Becomes Sacred

Paper 4 — (progressively harder)

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	8 — How the Land Becomes Sacred
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct. Watch the classic traps: sacredness is NOT confined to buildings (rivers, hills, forests, trees and whole journeys count); pilgrimage and trade routes OVERLAPPED rather than staying apart; many sites are SHARED across faiths; sacred groves rest on community BELIEF, not state law; the Kumbh ROTATES among four cities on a roughly 12-year sky-based cycle (not yearly, not one fixed place); keep char dham = 4, jyotirlingas = 12, Shakti pithas = 51 straight; sacred geography UNIFIED a diverse land and is NOT unique to India. Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

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1. A teacher draws a diagram with 'tirtha' at the centre and arrows to 'river ford', 'Tirthankara' and 'hilltop shrine'. The single idea that links all three branches is:
 - (A) the notion of a crossing from ordinary life toward a higher, spiritual state
 - (B) the requirement that each site sit physically beside flowing water
 - (C) the granting of tax-free land to the teachers who founded them
 - (D) the rule that only one religion may use each of them
 2. Which sequence correctly orders these from the SMALLEST traditional count to the LARGEST: Shakti pithas, char dham, jyotirlingas?
 - (A) jyotirlingas (12), char dham (4), Shakti pithas (51)
 - (B) char dham (4), Shakti pithas (51), jyotirlingas (12)
 - (C) Shakti pithas (51), jyotirlingas (12), char dham (4)
 - (D) char dham (4), jyotirlingas (12), Shakti pithas (51)
 3. Three of the following turn the WHOLE land into a sacred geography. Which one does NOT belong with the others?

- (A) networks of shrines deliberately scattered to the four edges of the country
- (B) rivers, mountains and forests revered as holy across many regions
- (C) long pilgrim journeys that carry people and customs from region to region
- (D) a single coin minted to advertise a ruler's military power

4. A pilgrim grumbles that the steep, exhausting climb to a hilltop shrine is pointless. The chapter's strongest reply is that the difficulty:

- (A) exists to ensure only the physically strongest are ever allowed to worship
- (B) is an unplanned accident of where the shrine happens to stand
- (C) mirrors the inner effort of spiritual growth, so the hardship itself carries meaning
- (D) is meant to keep pilgrims away so the shrine stays empty

5. If sacred sites had been clustered in one small region instead of scattered nationwide, the chapter's argument about INTEGRATION would have been weakened because:

- (A) the sites would have lost their connection to rivers and confluences
- (B) pilgrims would not have travelled long distances mixing people and customs across regions
- (C) the government would have refused to recognise them as holy
- (D) the festivals at the sites would have been cancelled for lack of pilgrims

6. Which pairing of a holy place with the religion it ORIGINATED with is correctly matched?

- (A) the 51 Shakti pithas — Jainism
- (B) Bodhi tree at Bodh Gaya — Buddhism
- (C) the 12 jyotirlingas — Buddhism
- (D) the char dham — Sikhism

7. A historian overlays a map of medieval pilgrimage routes on a map of major trade routes and finds they largely coincide. The best explanation the chapter offers is that:

- (A) pilgrims and traders were each assigned separate, non-overlapping roads by custom
- (B) the same well-travelled roads served both pilgrims and traders, so the routes overlapped
- (C) trade routes were only ever built long after pilgrimage had ceased
- (D) the overlap is pure coincidence with no underlying cause

8. Why does the chapter treat a sangam as an especially fitting kind of tirtha?

- (A) because waters meeting and crossing there embody the very idea of a sacred crossing point
- (B) because the rivers stop flowing there and the still water becomes holy
- (C) because bathing is banned there, which deepens its mystery
- (D) because it marks the tax boundary dividing two kingdoms

9. A student writes, 'The Kumbh Mela is held every year at Prayagraj and nowhere else.' How many separate errors does this single sentence contain?

- (A) two — it is not yearly, and it is not confined to Prayagraj alone
- (B) none — the sentence is entirely correct
- (C) one — only the city is wrong; the timing is right
- (D) three — the city, the timing, and the very existence of the festival are all wrong

10. The name 'Kumbh Mela' joins 'kumbh' and 'mela'. The legend behind the 'kumbh' part involves a:

- (A) mountain from which a sacred river was said to spring
- (B) pot that held amrita, the nectar of immortality
- (C) crown placed on the first king to bathe in the Ganga
- (D) fig tree under which the festival was first proclaimed

11. Which observation best shows that, in India, economic life and sacred life were closely woven together rather than kept apart?

- (A) pilgrims were required by custom to carry no money on any journey
- (B) the English name 'banyan' comes from the 'banias' (traders) who gathered in the tree's shade
- (C) traders were paid by shrines to keep well away from holy sites
- (D) trade was outlawed everywhere except inside temple compounds

12. A grove near a village shelters rare birds and a year-round spring, yet has no fence and no forest guard. The chapter would explain its survival by pointing to:

- (A) community belief that the grove is a deity's home, so harming it offends the divine
- (B) strict government laws enforced by regular police patrols
- (C) a tall boundary wall with permanently locked gates
- (D) annual cash payments the king makes to the villagers

13. Assertion (A): Pilgrimage centres in India often grew into busy market towns. Reason (R): Crowds of travelling pilgrims created steady demand for food, lodging and supplies that traders settled to meet. Choose the best evaluation.

- (A) Both A and R are true, but R does not explain A
- (B) Both A and R are true, and R correctly explains A
- (C) A is true but R is false
- (D) A is false but R is true

14. Which set of religions is made up ENTIRELY of faiths that ORIGINATED in India?

- (A) Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism
- (B) Hinduism, Buddhism, Islam and Sikhism
- (C) Jainism, Sikhism, Christianity and Hinduism
- (D) Buddhism, Zoroastrianism, Jainism and Hinduism

15. Sufi dargahs in India draw Hindus, Muslims and others to a single shrine. The chapter uses this chiefly to make the point that:

- (A) dargahs were originally temples that simply changed their religion
- (B) each Indian sacred site is reserved for exactly one faith
- (C) many holy places in India are revered across several faiths and communities
- (D) such shared worship is a recent fashion borrowed from abroad

16. Why does scattering 51 Shakti pithas across the subcontinent matter for the chapter's MAIN argument?

- (A) the deliberate spread bound far-apart regions into one shared sacred landscape
- (B) it sealed each region's goddess worship off from every other
- (C) it confined worship of the goddess to a single northern city
- (D) it replaced all river worship with shrine worship

17. A 'relic' kept at a shrine differs from a 'sangam' in that a relic is:

- (A) a meeting of rivers, while a sangam is a holy figure's belonging
- (B) a tax-free land grant, while a sangam is a counted dating era
- (C) a sky-based festival cycle, while a sangam is a fig tree
- (D) a part or belonging of a holy figure, while a sangam is a meeting of rivers

18. Calling a sacred mountain a 'gateway to heaven' best illustrates which idea from the chapter?

- (A) geography, culture and spirituality fuse so a landform carries religious meaning
- (B) only flat plains, never heights, can ever be regarded as sacred
- (C) geography and religion are deliberately kept separate in India
- (D) mountains are valued only as boundaries no traveller may cross

19. The banyan can spread to shelter a large gathering of people under one tree. The botanical reason the chapter gives is that its:

- (A) leaves turn to gold each spring, widening its canopy
- (B) trunk is naturally made of stone, letting it grow huge
- (C) flowers bloom only during the Kumbh, drawing crowds
- (D) hanging aerial roots grow down and harden into new trunks

20. A claim states: 'Sacred geography of this kind is found only in India.' The chapter would judge this claim:

- (A) correct, because no other country has any holy places at all
- (B) correct, because the very idea was invented in modern Europe
- (C) mistaken, because India in fact has no sacred geography
- (D) mistaken, because reverence for sacred landscapes is found in other parts of the world too

21. Which conclusion about India's sacred geography is BEST supported by the chapter as a whole?

- (A) it blended faith, Nature and movement across the land into a force that long unified a diverse subcontinent
- (B) it mattered only to traders pursuing profit along the routes
- (C) it permanently divided India into mutually hostile faiths
- (D) it appeared only in modern times and had no earlier history

22. Why does the chapter call the long climb to a hilltop shrine 'meaningful' rather than simply 'inconvenient'?

- (A) the fastest possible route to any shrine is always the most sacred
- (B) it proves which pilgrim is physically the strongest of the group
- (C) the effort of the outer journey is felt to reflect the effort of inner spiritual growth
- (D) it lets pilgrims avoid every contact with the natural world

23. Across Hindu, Buddhist and Jain traditions the word 'tirtha' or its relatives keep reappearing. The deepest shared meaning the chapter draws is that sacredness is widely understood as:

- (A) a crossing from the ordinary world toward a higher, liberated state
- (B) the amount of land that a temple owns and controls
- (C) the military strength of the kingdom that protects the site
- (D) the age in years of the oldest shrine in each region

24. Treating a forest grove as a deity's home does 'double duty' in the chapter's argument because it simultaneously:

- (A) turns the forest into state property that police must guard
- (B) encourages villagers to log and mine it for quick income
- (C) proves that only buildings, never forests, can be sacred
- (D) expresses reverence for Nature and conserves a living ecosystem

25. Which choice BEST captures a 'punyakshetra', where geography, culture and spirituality fuse?

- (A) a coin minted to advertise a ruler's power
- (B) a copper plate recording a tax-free land grant
- (C) a court poet's inscription praising a king
- (D) a riverbank or forest revered as holy, where pilgrims gather and Nature is protected

26. How did the great epics help SCATTER sacred sites across India?

- (A) by linking many places to the journeys and deeds of their heroes, making those places holy
- (B) by forbidding pilgrimage to every place they happened to name
- (C) by naming only one single holy place in all of India
- (D) by describing imaginary lands with no real locations at all

27. Why does the chapter say sacred geography helped 'integrate' the subcontinent rather than divide it?

- (A) pilgrims moving between far-flung sites carried ideas, stories and customs across regions
- (B) everyone was forced to adopt a single common language
- (C) each region was sealed off and kept entirely to itself
- (D) all regional kingdoms were abolished to form one state

28. Long-surviving sacred groves with rich biodiversity are presented in the chapter as evidence that:

- (A) conservation only ever succeeds when enforced by the police
- (B) belief can conserve Nature effectively even without formal legal protection
- (C) religious belief always damages the natural environment
- (D) forests can be protected only inside city limits

29. A traveller links Badrinath, Dwarka, Puri and Rameswaram in one long journey. The placement of these four shrines BEST shows that they were chosen to:

- (A) stand close together inside a single northern valley
- (B) lie entirely outside the borders of India
- (C) ring the land at its north, west, east and south, tying distant corners together
- (D) cluster in one city as four separate temples

30. Which statement about the jyotirlingas is correct?

- (A) they are fifty-one shrines dedicated to the goddess
- (B) they are four shrines dedicated to Vishnu
- (C) they are twelve shrines, all dedicated to Shiva
- (D) they are seven shrines dedicated to the Buddha

31. Why does the chapter describe natural places such as rivers, hills and groves as sacred 'across many religions and communities'?

- (A) the government assigns each natural feature to one religion at a time
- (B) people of different faiths sharing a region have come to revere the same natural features
- (C) only the oldest religion is permitted to revere Nature
- (D) such reverence lasts only a single year before being reassigned

32. A faith that arrived in India from OUTSIDE came to have deeply revered sites here mainly because:

- (A) each outside faith was given exactly one site by royal decree and no more
- (B) such faiths simply renamed existing temples without changing anything
- (C) over centuries its followers settled, built and honoured holy places, weaving them into India's sacred geography
- (D) only the government could grant an outside faith any sacred place

33. The Bodhi tree under which the Buddha is said to have attained enlightenment was a peepal. The chapter highlights this to argue that:

- (A) trees themselves can be sacred, so holiness reaches beyond built shrines into living Nature
- (B) sacredness in India is limited to temples and other buildings
- (C) only fig trees, and no other part of Nature, can ever be holy
- (D) the Buddha forbade his followers from revering any natural place

34. Which best explains why a single famous shrine often sat at the junction of several pilgrimage AND trade routes?

- (A) the constant flow of both pilgrims and traders made such junctions naturally busy and important
- (B) shrines were forbidden anywhere except at empty crossroads
- (C) traders were paid to keep all their routes away from shrines
- (D) pilgrims and traders were never allowed to meet on the same road

35. A 'shrine' is regarded as holy chiefly because of its association with:

- (A) a famous battle and nothing more
- (B) the divine, a sacred relic, or a revered spiritual figure
- (C) a busy market town and nothing more
- (D) a royal coronation and nothing more

36. Pilgrims at the Kumbh Mela bathe at the river or its sangam. Linking the festival to a confluence chiefly reinforces which earlier idea?

- (A) the festival has no real connection to rivers at all
- (B) a sangam is a sacred crossing place fitting the tirtha idea, which draws huge gatherings
- (C) confluences are avoided because bathing there is forbidden
- (D) the Kumbh is held on a hilltop far from any water

37. Which fact about the TIMING of the Kumbh Mela is correct?

- (A) it is fixed each year by a vote of the local kings
- (B) it begins with the first rainfall of every monsoon
- (C) it is set by the positions of Jupiter and the Sun on a roughly twelve-year cycle
- (D) it is triggered whenever a new temple is completed nearby

38. Assertion (A): Treating the whole land as sacred has helped conserve Nature in India. Reason (R): When rivers, mountains and forests are seen as holy, people gain a strong motive to protect them. Choose the best evaluation.

- (A) Both A and R are true, but R does not explain A
- (B) A is true but R is false
- (C) A is false but R is true
- (D) Both A and R are true, and R correctly explains A

39. 'Conservation', as the chapter ties it to sacred places, means:

- (A) clearing forests quickly for the largest possible profit
- (B) building over rivers and confluences to expand cities
- (C) discarding old traditions in favour of new constructions
- (D) protecting and keeping Nature, biodiversity or heritage safe for the future

40. Which statement about the duty to protect sacred places today follows MOST directly from the chapter?

- (A) they are useless relics of the past best left to decay
- (B) they matter only for the tourism income they bring
- (C) they are the private property of traders alone
- (D) they are a shared heritage of Nature and culture, so protecting them is worthwhile for everyone

41. The peepal (*Ficus religiosa*) is revered across several Indian faiths. The chapter highlights such a tree mainly to show that:

- (A) only the peepal among all trees has ever been considered holy
- (B) trees are sacred only to the one faith that first revered them
- (C) living elements of Nature, not only built structures, can be objects of shared reverence
- (D) reverence for Nature is found in exactly one religion

42. The phrase 'sacred geography' is best understood to mean that:

- (A) only one mountain in the entire country counts as holy
- (B) geography lessons must be taught inside temple grounds
- (C) holy places are spread across the territory so that the land itself comes to feel sacred
- (D) India keeps no record or map of where its holy sites lie

43. Which example BEST shows that one sacred place can matter to MORE THAN ONE religious tradition?

- (A) a temple that admits worshippers of only its own sect
- (B) a site such as a Sufi dargah honoured by people of several different faiths
- (C) a royal palace open exclusively to the king's family
- (D) a market square used solely for buying and selling

44. Across India, river confluences, hilltop shrines and ocean-edge temples are ALL called tirthas. The unifying reason is that each is imagined as a:

- (A) place where rivers physically begin their flow
- (B) boundary stone marking the edge of a kingdom
- (C) crossing point between the ordinary world and a higher, sacred realm
- (D) site reserved only for royal ceremonies

45. River and confluence worship in India is described as reaching back to:

- (A) only the last hundred years, as a modern movement
- (B) at least Vedic times, making it among the oldest of practices
- (C) only the period after the Gupta empire fell
- (D) only the era of large modern cities

46. Which pairing of the two LARGEST networks gives the right counts?

- (A) jyotirlingas number 12 and Shakti pithas number 51
- (B) jyotirlingas number 51 and Shakti pithas number 12
- (C) jyotirlingas number 4 and Shakti pithas number 12
- (D) jyotirlingas number 51 and Shakti pithas number 4

47. A Tirthankara in Jainism is best described as:

- (A) a river formed where two streams meet
- (B) a king who grants tax-free land to teachers
- (C) a supreme teacher of dharma — literally 'one who makes a tirtha (crossing)'
- (D) a giant fig tree revered by a community

48. Why does the chapter say a far-flung, hard-to-reach set of holy sites actually helped UNIFY rather than fragment India?

- (A) the distances kept every region permanently apart from the others
- (B) only one of the sites was ever truly visited by anyone
- (C) reaching them meant long journeys that mixed people, languages and customs across regions
- (D) travel between regions was forbidden to ordinary people

49. Which best shows that, in India, geography and spirituality 'fuse together'?

- (A) a temple is built and the surrounding landscape is then ignored
- (B) a mountain or river is itself worshipped as divine, not merely as a backdrop to worship
- (C) worship happens only indoors, away from any natural feature
- (D) natural features are valued purely for farming and never for faith

50. A student says, 'Sacred groves are protected by strict government laws.' The most accurate response is that this is:

- (A) completely correct, since belief plays no role at all
- (B) correct, because such groves are not really protected in any way
- (C) mistaken, because sacred groves do not actually exist
- (D) largely mistaken — groves are protected mainly by community belief, not by law

51. Three of the following are revered LIVING things in the chapter. Which one is NOT a living thing at all?

- | | |
|--------------|--------------------|
| (A) a peepal | (B) a sangam |
| (C) a banyan | (D) the Bodhi tree |

52. Which best explains why busy pilgrimage routes naturally turned into trading routes too?

- (A) sacred sites specifically paid traders to stay far away
- (B) pilgrims were required by custom to carry no possessions
- (C) trade was outlawed everywhere except inside temples
- (D) large numbers of travelling pilgrims created steady demand for food, supplies and lodging that traders supplied

53. The chapter says sacred geography knit India together 'for at least three thousand years.' This long span is meant to show that the integrating force was:

- (A) a brief modern campaign limited to recent decades
- (B) deep and continuous, shaping the civilisation over a vast stretch of time
- (C) active only during the rule of one particular dynasty
- (D) something that operated for a single century and then stopped

54. The big idea 'how the land becomes sacred' is best summed up as:

- (A) only a single temple in India is truly holy
- (B) land becomes sacred only when a king formally declares it so
- (C) sacredness has nothing to do with geography at all
- (D) through pilgrimage, networks of sites and revered Nature, the whole land — not just shrines — comes to be seen as holy

55. Which set correctly names the four char dham that ring the country?

- (A) Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik and Ujjain
- (B) Bodh Gaya, Sarnath, Kushinagar and Lumbini
- (C) Badrinath, Dwarka, Puri and Rameswaram
- (D) Badrinath, Kanchipuram, Madurai and Dwarka

56. Sacred groves survive because harming them is felt to offend a deity. The best GENERAL lesson the chapter draws from this is that:

- (A) environmental protection is impossible without modern technology
- (B) belief and conservation are opposing forces that cannot coexist
- (C) only urban authorities can ever safeguard a forest
- (D) cultural belief can be a powerful tool for protecting the environment

57. The Sanskrit word 'tirtha' literally means a:

- (A) mountain peak that reaches the sky
- (B) pot that holds the nectar of immortality
- (C) place to cross a river — and, by extension, a crossing from ordinary to higher life
- (D) grove that a village sets aside and protects

58. A 'sacred grove' is best defined as a:

- (A) patch of natural forest a community protects as the dwelling of a deity
- (B) planted royal garden on which the king levies a tax

- (C) market square set aside at the centre of a town
- (D) confluence where two or more rivers meet and join

59. Which single change would do the MOST to weaken the chapter's claim that pilgrimage and trade were intertwined?

- (A) showing that pilgrims travelled long distances to reach far-off shrines
- (B) showing that some shrines stood at busy crossroads
- (C) showing that festivals drew large crowds to riverbanks
- (D) showing that pilgrims and traders deliberately used wholly separate roads

60. A student writes: 'In India you don't only visit the sacred — you can travel through a sacred land.' The strongest support from the chapter is that:

- (A) there is exactly one holy building in the entire country
- (B) sacredness ends precisely at a temple's outer walls
- (C) networks of holy sites together with revered rivers, mountains and forests turn the whole territory into a sacred geography
- (D) only foreigners regard India's open land as holy

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 8: How the Land Becomes Sacred — Paper 4

Paper 4 — (progressively harder)

Marking: +4 correct, –1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	A	11	B	21	A	31	B	41	C	51	B
2	D	12	A	22	C	32	C	42	C	52	D
3	D	13	B	23	A	33	A	43	B	53	B
4	C	14	A	24	D	34	A	44	C	54	D
5	B	15	C	25	D	35	B	45	B	55	C
6	B	16	A	26	A	36	B	46	A	56	D
7	B	17	D	27	A	37	C	47	C	57	C
8	A	18	A	28	B	38	D	48	C	58	A
9	A	19	D	29	C	39	D	49	B	59	D
10	B	20	D	30	C	40	D	50	D	60	C

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

1. (A) All three share the root sense of 'crossing': a ford crosses a river, a Tirthankara 'makes a crossing' to liberation, and a hilltop shrine is reached by a journey symbolising inner ascent — so the common thread is the crossing to a higher state. They need not lie beside water (hilltop and Tirthankara branches have no river); the link is symbolic, not a land-grant; and tirthas are often shared across faiths, not single-religion.

2. (D) The traditional counts are char dham 4, jyotirlingas 12, Shakti pithas 51, so smallest-to-largest is 4, 12, 51 = char dham, jyotirlingas, Shakti pithas. The other orderings misplace one network — putting jyotirlingas first, or Shakti pithas before jyotirlingas, or reversing the whole list — and so break the $4 < 12 < 51$ sequence.

3. (D) Scattered shrine-networks, revered natural features, and cross-country pilgrim journeys all spread holiness across the territory, making the land itself sacred. A coin advertising a ruler's power is a political/economic object with no role in sacralising the landscape, so it is the odd one out.

4. (C) The chapter reads the outer hardship of the climb as a mirror of the inner spiritual effort, which is precisely what gives the journey meaning. It is not a test reserving worship for the strong, not a meaningless accident, and not a device to keep pilgrims out — the difficulty is part of the symbolism, not a barrier.

5. (B) Integration worked because far-flung sites forced long journeys that mixed people, languages and customs across regions; clustering them would remove that long-distance mixing. The other options invent consequences the chapter never claims — sanctity does not depend on rivers, government recognition, or festival attendance for the integration argument to hold.

6. (B) The Bodhi (peepal) tree at Bodh Gaya is tied to the Buddha's enlightenment, so it pairs with Buddhism. The Shakti pithas belong to goddess worship (Hindu tradition), not Jainism; the jyotirlingas are Shiva shrines (Hindu), not Buddhist; and the char dham are Hindu abodes, not Sikh sites.

7. (B) Crowds of pilgrims created steady demand for goods and lodging, so traders used the same roads — making the maps coincide for a real reason. The chapter denies that the routes were kept separate, that trade waited until pilgrimage ended, or that the match is mere coincidence; the overlap reflects intertwined religious and economic life.

8. (A) A confluence is literally a crossing-and-joining of waters, which matches the core tirtha idea of a sacred crossing — hence its special status. Rivers do not stop flowing at a sangam, bathing there is encouraged rather than banned, and its sanctity has nothing to do with tax borders.

9. (A) The Kumbh rotates among four cities (Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik, Ujjain) on a roughly twelve-year sky-based cycle, so the sentence is wrong about being yearly AND about being confined to Prayagraj — exactly two errors. It is not error-free, not a single-error timing-correct claim, and the festival does genuinely exist, so 'three errors' overcounts.

10. (B) 'Kumbh' means pot and recalls the legendary pot of amrita (nectar), while 'mela' means a fair or gathering. The other choices substitute a mountain-source, a royal crown, or a fig tree — none of which the kumbh element refers to.

11. (B) Traders ('banias') gathering under a revered tree, lending it their name, neatly shows commerce and the sacred mingling. The distractors describe the opposite — moneyless pilgrims, traders paid to stay away, or trade banned outside temples — all of which the chapter rejects, since pilgrim demand actually drew commerce in.

12. (A) Sacred groves are guarded chiefly by the community's belief that the grove houses a deity, making harm a sacrilege — which is why they survive without fences or guards. They are not primarily protected by state law and police, nor by walls and gates, nor by royal payments; belief does the protecting.

13. (B) Pilgrim crowds generated continuous demand, drawing traders who settled along the routes, so towns grew around the sites — R is the genuine cause of A and both are true. It is not an unrelated true reason, and neither statement is false; the pilgrimage-and-trade overlap is exactly the engine described.

14. (A) Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism all arose within India, so that set is entirely India-born. Each other set slips in a faith that came from outside — Islam, Christianity, or Zoroastrianism — and so is not made up only of India-born religions.

15. (C) Shared veneration at dargahs shows that many sacred sites cross religious lines, which is the intended point. It is not a story of sites changing religion, it directly contradicts the 'one site, one faith' idea, and pilgrimage and shared worship in India are ancient, not a modern import.

16. (A) Spreading pithas everywhere meant devotees everywhere shared one connected geography, knitting regions together — supporting the integration theme. It did the opposite of sealing regions off, was not confined to one city, and did not displace river worship, which continued alongside it.

17. (D) A relic is a bodily remain or possession of a revered figure; a sangam is the confluence where rivers meet — so the first option pairs them correctly. The others swap the two definitions or substitute unrelated terms (land grants, dating eras, festival cycles, fig trees) that belong to neither word.

18. (A) Reading a peak's height as an ascent toward the divine shows land and faith merging — the landform itself becomes spiritually charged. This contradicts the notions that only flat land is sacred, that geography and religion stay apart, or that mountains matter only as borders.

19. (D) The banyan's hanging aerial roots descend and become new trunks, so a single tree covers a wide area and can shade large gatherings. Its leaves do not turn gold, its trunk is wood and not stone, and its flowering has no link to the Kumbh — those are invented details.

20. (D) The chapter notes that sacred geography exists elsewhere as well, so the word 'only' makes the claim wrong. Other countries do have holy places, the idea was not a modern European invention, and India clearly does possess a rich sacred geography — so the single error is the claim of uniqueness.

21. (A) The chapter ties faith, revered Nature and pilgrim movement into a unifying force operating across millennia, so this is the best-supported conclusion. It was not merely a traders' concern, did not divide India into hostile camps, and is ancient rather than recent.

22. (C) The outer hardship is read as a reflection of the inner spiritual effort, which is what makes it meaningful rather than a mere nuisance. The hard climb is slower not

faster, it is not a contest of strength, and it passes through Nature rather than avoiding it.

23. (A) The recurring 'crossing' root unites these faiths around the idea of passing from ordinary life to a higher, liberated state. It has nothing to do with temple landholdings, the strength of a kingdom, or the age of shrines — the common thread is spiritual crossing.

24. (D) A grove seen as a deity's home both honours Nature and protects a living ecosystem — reverence and conservation reinforcing each other. It does not make the grove police-guarded state property, it forbids rather than encourages logging and mining, and it shows forests can indeed be sacred.

25. (D) A revered riverbank or forest that draws pilgrims and shelters Nature shows land, culture and spirit merging — the essence of a punyakshetra. A coin, a land-grant plate and a praise-inscription are political or economic records, not fusions of geography with the sacred.

26. (A) The epics tied heroes' journeys and deeds to many real locations, seeding holy spots everywhere and binding regions through a shared story. They did not ban pilgrimage, did not name just one place, and did describe real places, so the other options misread their role.

27. (A) Pilgrims crisscrossing the land spread shared stories and customs, weaving diverse regions into one civilisation. Integration came through movement and shared sacredness, not through forced linguistic uniformity, regional isolation, or the abolition of kingdoms.

28. (B) Groves that have lasted for centuries show that belief alone can safeguard biodiversity and water without statutes — the chapter's lesson. This contradicts the claims that conservation needs police, that belief harms Nature, and that forests survive only in cities.

29. (C) The char dham sit at the four cardinal edges — Badrinath (north), Dwarka (west), Puri (east), Rameswaram (south) — so linking them ties far-apart corners into one sacred geography. They are not packed into one valley, not outside India, and not gathered in a single city.

30. (C) The jyotirlingas form a network of twelve shrines of Shiva. Fifty-one with the goddess describes the Shakti pithas; four with Vishnu suggests the char dham; and the Buddha is not the focus of any such linga network, so the other options misassign both number and deity.

31. (B) Communities of varied faiths living together have often come to honour the same river, hill or grove, so the reverence is shared. It is not parcelled out by government, not reserved for the oldest religion, and not a temporary yearly grant — those options invent rules the chapter never states.

32. (C) Incoming communities put down roots and established their own honoured sites over time, which became part of India's sacred landscape. It was not a one-site royal allotment, not mere renaming of temples, and not dependent on government grants — it grew through settlement and devotion.

33. (A) A revered living tree shows sacredness spilling beyond buildings into Nature itself. It refutes the 'buildings only' idea; it is an example, not a claim that only fig trees can be holy (rivers, mountains and groves count too); and it involves no ban on revering Nature.

34. (A) Junctions drew both pilgrims and traders, so a shrine there sat amid heavy, overlapping traffic — making it busy and important. Shrines were not restricted to empty crossroads, traders were not paid to avoid them, and pilgrims and traders did share the roads.

35. (B) A shrine's holiness comes from its tie to the divine, a relic, or a holy person. Battles, markets and coronations are military, commercial or royal associations — not what makes a place a shrine.

36. (B) Holding the Kumbh at river confluences reinforces the sangam-as-tirtha idea — a sacred crossing place that draws huge crowds. The festival is deeply tied to rivers, bathing is central rather than forbidden, and it is a riverbank fair, not a hilltop event.

37. (C) The Kumbh's timing follows astronomical positions of Jupiter and the Sun over roughly twelve years. It is not decided by a royal vote, not tied to the monsoon's first rain, and not triggered by temple-building — those are invented mechanisms.

38. (D) Seeing Nature as sacred gives people a powerful reason to safeguard it, so the reverence drives the conservation — R genuinely explains A, and both are true. It is not an unrelated true reason, and neither statement is false; the causal link is exactly what the chapter argues.

39. (D) Conservation is safeguarding Nature and heritage for the future, which is what reverence for sacred places achieves. It is the opposite of clearing forests for profit, building over rivers, or discarding tradition.

40. (D) Seeing sacred sites as a shared natural and cultural heritage makes their protection a common responsibility. They are not useless relics, not valued only for tourist money, and not the property of any single group.

41. (C) A widely revered tree shows Nature itself being held sacred, beyond buildings and across faiths. It is not a claim that only the peepal is holy (the banyan and others count too), the reverence is shared rather than tied to one founding faith, and it spans multiple religions.

- 42. (C)** Sacred geography means holiness distributed across the land until the whole territory feels sacred. It is not about a single holy mountain, not about where geography is taught, and not a claim that holy sites go unmapped.
- 43. (B)** A dargah drawing devotees of several faiths directly shows multi-faith sacredness. A single-sect temple is the opposite case, a palace is not a shared sacred site, and a market is a commercial space, not a holy one revered across faiths.
- 44. (C)** What unites these varied places is the shared idea of a sacred crossing from the ordinary to the higher. None of them is defined by being a river source, a kingdom boundary, or a royal-only venue — the common thread is the symbolic crossing.
- 45. (B)** River and confluence worship goes back at least to Vedic times, so it is among the oldest practices. It is not a recent or modern-city phenomenon, and it long predates rather than follows the Guptas.
- 46. (A)** Shiva's jyotirlingas number 12 and the goddess's Shakti pithas number 51. The other pairings swap or shrink these figures; the reliable memory is 12 lingas and 51 pithas.
- 47. (C)** A Tirthankara is a great Jain teacher who 'makes a crossing' to liberation. It is not a river (that is a sangam), not a land-granting king, and not a tree — the title is about spiritual crossing.
- 48. (C)** Long pilgrimages forced contact and exchange among people from many regions, weaving them together. Distance did not isolate regions here, more than one site was visited, and ordinary people did make these journeys — the mixing produced unity.
- 49. (B)** When the land feature itself is treated as divine, geography and spirituality have truly merged. Ignoring the landscape, worshipping only indoors, or valuing Nature solely for farming would all keep geography and faith apart.
- 50. (D)** Community belief, not government law, is the main protector of sacred groves, so the claim is largely wrong. Belief plays the central role, the groves are genuinely protected, and they certainly do exist.
- 51. (B)** A sangam is a confluence where rivers meet — a place, not a living thing. The peepal, the banyan and the Bodhi tree are all revered living trees, so the sangam is the odd one out.
- 52. (D)** Crowds of pilgrims meant constant demand, which traders met, so devotion and commerce shared the same roads. Sites did not pay traders to leave, pilgrims did carry goods and money, and trade was not banned outside temples — the demand drew commerce in.

- 53. (B)** Three thousand years signals a deep, continuous influence on the civilisation, not a passing event. It rules out a modern campaign, a single-dynasty episode, or a one-century burst — the integration has been long and sustained.
- 54. (D)** The land becomes sacred through pilgrim journeys, networks and revered Nature, so the whole territory feels holy. It is not limited to one temple, does not require a royal declaration, and is intimately bound up with geography rather than separate from it.
- 55. (C)** The classic char dham are Badrinath, Dwarka, Puri and Rameswaram, set at the four cardinal edges. Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik and Ujjain are the Kumbh cities; Bodh Gaya, Sarnath and the like are Buddhist sites; and the last set mixes in cities outside the standard char dham.
- 56. (D)** Belief that protects groves shows culture and conservation working together effectively — the general lesson. It contradicts the claims that technology is essential, that belief and conservation conflict, and that only city authorities can protect forests.
- 57. (C)** Tirtha literally means a ford or crossing place, which becomes a symbol of crossing toward the divine. It does not mean a peak, a nectar-pot (that echoes 'kumbh'), or a grove (that is a sacred grove).
- 58. (A)** A sacred grove is a tract of natural forest that a community protects because it is seen as a deity's home. It is not a taxed royal garden, not a town market square, and not a river confluence (that is a sangam) — those describe entirely different things.
- 59. (D)** The intertwining claim rests on pilgrims and traders sharing the same roads, so proving they used wholly separate roads would directly undercut it. The other facts — long pilgrim journeys, shrines at busy crossroads, crowds at festivals — actually reinforce the overlap rather than weaken it.
- 60. (C)** Because site-networks plus sacred Nature spread holiness across the land, one truly travels through a sacred geography. India has many holy places, not one building; sacredness extends well beyond temple walls; and the reverence is held by Indians themselves.